



Manufacturing **Threat Landscape** Report

Reporting Period: January 1 to March 31, 2026

Ransomware & Data-Leak Sites

Ransomware remains a top cyber threat to all organizations globally. This section showcases the top ransomware groups targeting the manufacturing sector and what you can do about them.

442

ransomware attacks

▲ 22%

since last reporting period
(October 1 to December 31, 2025)

Key Points and Recommendations

- Manufacturing victims posted to data-leak sites rose period over period, alongside a considerable expansion in the actor pool; however, this shift was heavily influenced by "0APT," a group that's assessed as highly likely to be posting fraudulent claims and that displaced "Qilin" and "Akira" from the top position.
- Although postings by Qilin and Akira declined, they remained persistent across both periods. "The Gentlemen" and "NightSpire," which exploits the FortiOS/FortiProxy authentication bypass CVE-2024-55591, grew substantially, reflecting increased breadth of active operators.
- Groups such as "Clop" and "Nova" posted fewer manufacturing targets this period, while "Inc Ransom" grew. Most sector victims for the top groups exceed their all-sector averages, suggesting the manufacturing sector is receiving disproportionate, not merely opportunistic, attention.
- Prioritize patching FortiOS vulnerabilities and enforce MFA on SonicWall and Cisco VPN appliances targeted by Akira; deploy EDR with living-off-the-land (LotL) behavioral rules; and block unauthorized data-staging tools such as Rclone via application allowlisting.

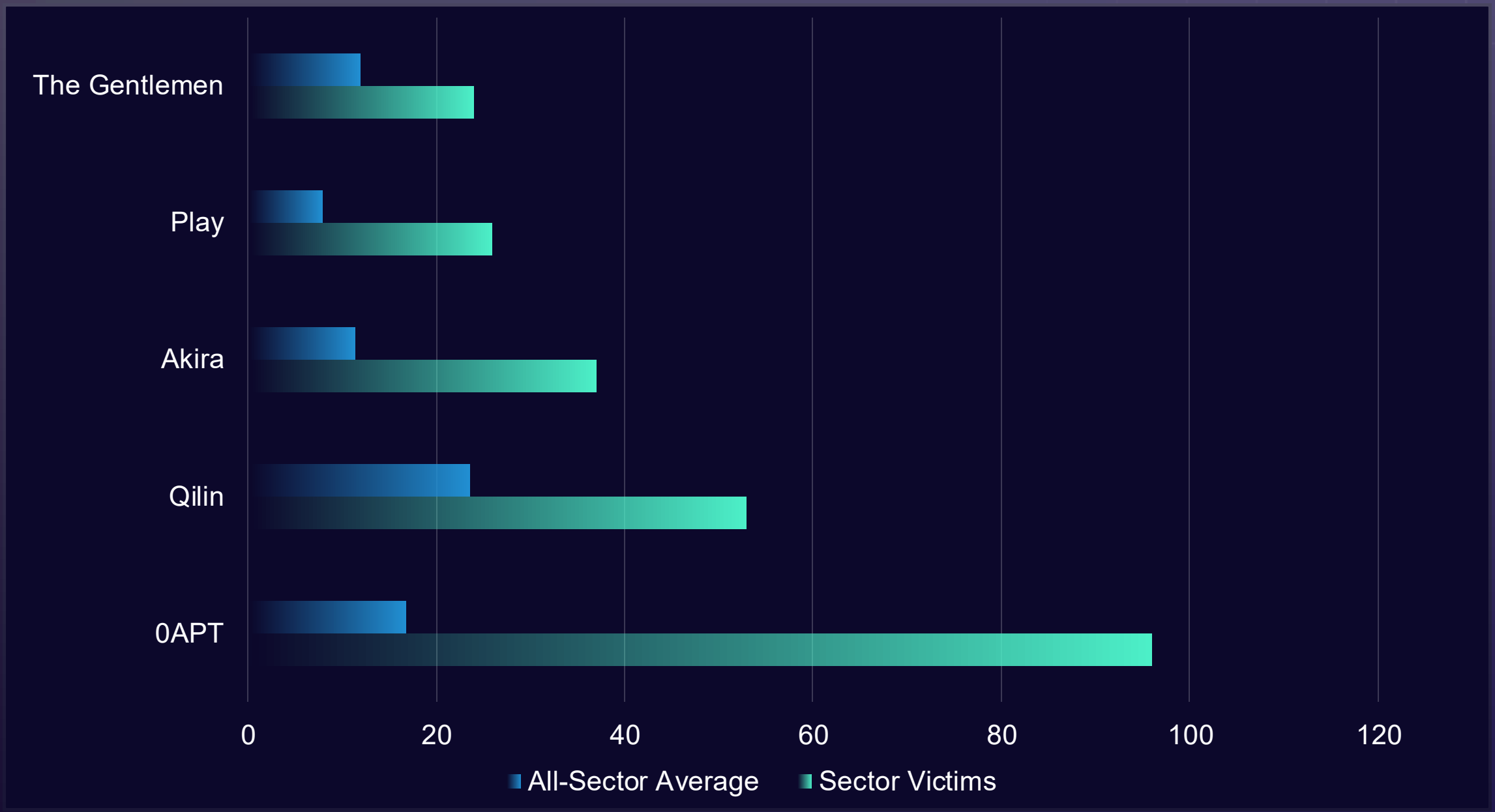


Figure 1: Number of manufacturing organizations named on data-leak sites vs. the average number of organizations named to data-leak sites across all sectors.

Vulnerability Exploitation

This section explores trends in vulnerability exploitation. It details how quickly attackers are exploiting vulnerabilities, which vulnerabilities are most discussed by cybercriminals and researchers, and key incidents from the reporting period.

The most recent quarter saw average time-to-exploitation rise to 13 days across 41 vulnerabilities, up 61% from eight days across 46 the prior quarter, likely indicating attackers targeted more complex, higher-value targets rather than easy opportunities. Rapid exploitation also declined, with same-day exploitation dropping from 21 to 10 CVEs and five-day exploitation from 28 to 20, suggesting fewer flaws were immediately or easily exploitable. Key examples include CVE-2026-20963, a Microsoft SharePoint remote-code execution (RCE) exploited by multiple threat actors, and CVE-2026-21643, a pre-auth SQL injection in Fortinet FortiClient Endpoint Management Server (EMS) that enables unauthenticated code execution, both likely favored for their broad enterprise exposure.

Popular CVEs

CVE	ReliaQuest Intelligence Mentions
CVE-2026-21509 - Microsoft Office RCE vulnerability	16
CVE-2026-20045 - Cisco Unified Communications critical vulnerability	7
CVE-2026-1731 - BeyondTrust Remote Support critical vulnerability	6
CVE-2026-24858 - Fortinet FortiAnalyzer FortiOS Critical flaw	6
CVE-2025-55182 - Meta React Server DOM vulnerability	6

41

new vulnerabilities exploited

▼ 11%

since last reporting period

Vulnerability Highlights

CVE-2026-33634

CVE-2026-33634 is a CVSS 6.3 embedded malicious code vulnerability in Aqua Security's trivy-action and setup-trivy GitHub Actions. Exploited in the wild since March 19, 2026, the threat actor "TeamPCP" used compromised credentials to inject credential-stealing malware into the tools' version tags, harvesting continuous integration/continuous delivery (CI/CD) pipeline secrets at scale. This incident has since entered a ransomware phase, with the "Vect" ransomware group confirmed as using stolen credentials from this supply-chain compromise to target victims.

Organizations using these tools in their CI/CD pipelines are at direct risk of credential and secrets theft, which can expose cloud environments and downstream systems. A clean version, setup-trivy v0.2.6, is available. Immediately upgrade, rotate all secrets exposed in affected pipelines, and pin GitHub Actions to a specific commit hash rather than mutable version tags per Aqua Security's advisory.

Attacker Target Insights

This section details the initial access attempts that are targeting ReliaQuest’s manufacturing customers. It also explores how quickly organizations in the sector are responding to threat actor activity. Our agentic AI security operations platform, GreyMatter, allows threats to be detected at the source and in transit. Security teams can contain, investigate, and respond in less than 5 minutes—eliminating Tier 1 and Tier 2 security operations work.

How fast did manufacturing organizations respond to cyber threats?

The mean time to contain (MTTC) threats decreased to **1 hour and 39 minutes** during the reporting period, down approximately 34% from **2 hours and 29 minutes** since the last reporting period. Manufacturing saw the most cyber attacks of any industry in 2025 for the fifth consecutive year, making this improvement in containment speed particularly significant.

↓ 34%

During the reporting period, organizations in the manufacturing sector using ReliaQuest Automated Response Playbooks achieved an average MTTC of 4 minutes when responding to threats.

Top Techniques

According to our customer incident data, attacks targeting the manufacturing sector increased by 264% during the reporting period, reflecting a substantial expansion in observed activity volume.

Phishing techniques combined fell to 15% from 23%, though Phishing for Information emerged as the top individual technique at 8%. Data from Removable Media rose to 2% from 0.9%, suggesting greater attention on physical-access vectors this period. Cloud Accounts and External Remote Services both saw notable drops, suggesting less emphasis on cloud and perimeter exploitation relative to prior activity.

Spearphishing Links, Internal Spearphishing, and Malicious File Delivery remain prevalent, but each saw substantial declines, while Removable Media and credential-focused techniques gained relative share.

Top MITRE Techniques Targeting Sector

MITRE ATT&CK Technique	Percentage of All Techniques Observed
Phishing for Information	8
Spearphishing Link	3
Data from Removable Media	2
Internal Spearphishing	2
Malicious File	2

Digital Risk Protection

This section explores the biggest GreyMatter Digital Risk Protection (DRP) risks to the manufacturing sector. If a risk is detected, customers receive context-rich alerts via the GreyMatter alert process, with clear response steps including assignment and mitigation recommendations.

Credential exposure alerts rose sharply in the manufacturing sector and now account for nearly half of all alerts. While impersonating domains increased in raw volume, they declined as a share of total activity, whereas expired certificate alerts saw a large increase. Taken together, these shifts suggest threat actors are prioritizing credential harvesting over spoofing infrastructure, likely to enable downstream supply-chain compromise or unauthorized system access.

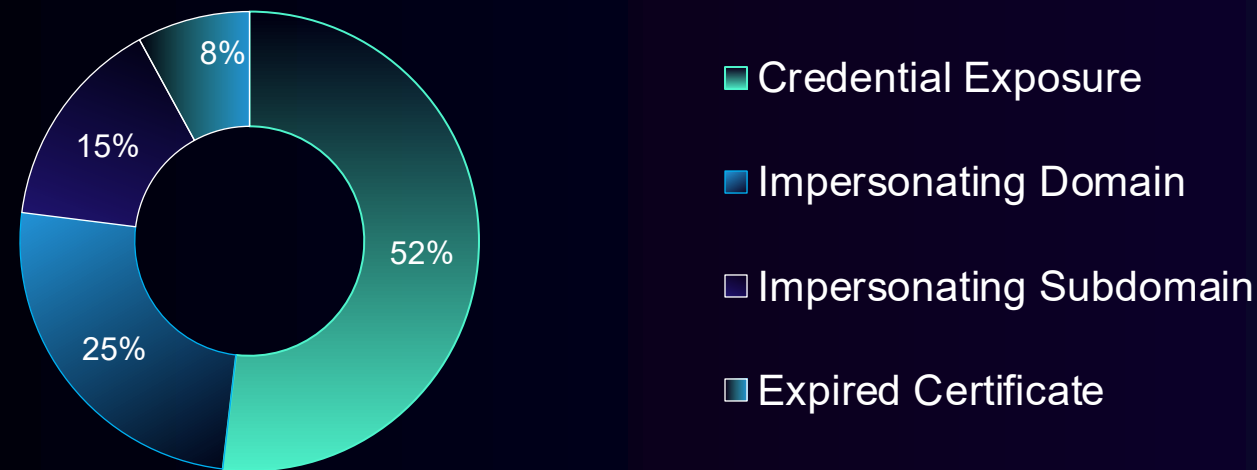


Figure 2: DRP alerts by type for manufacturing customers this reporting period

All-Sector Top DRP Alerts (for comparison)

Risk Type	Percentage
Credential Exposure	30
Impersonating Domain	24
Impersonating Subdomain	18
Selling Unauthorized Goods	7
Expired Certificate	6

Countries Targeted

Publicly known cyber events targeting organizations in the manufacturing sector show the US remains the dominant target, now accounting for 45% of total activity, though raw alert volume rose by roughly 22% period-over-period, consistent with manufacturers being the most ransomware-targeted industry globally entering 2026. Germany saw a decline, dropping by roughly 24%, likely reflecting natural fluctuation rather than a structural shift. Overall targeting was spread across a broader range of countries, suggesting increasingly opportunistic activity beyond traditional Western European concentrations.

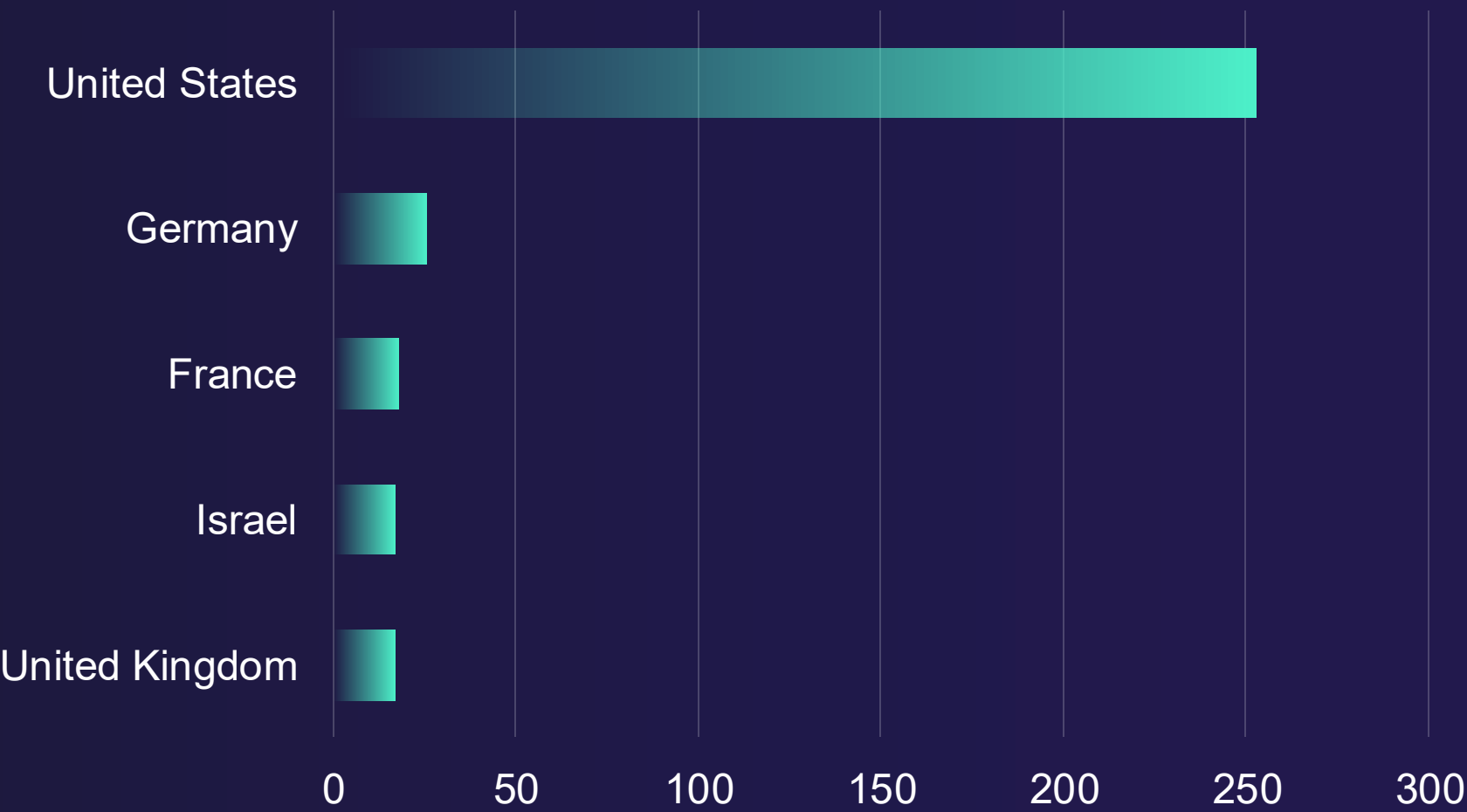


Figure 3: Number of significant cyber events, by region

Notable Developments

Axios Supply-Chain Attack Targets JavaScript Environments

North Korea-nexus threat actor "UNC1069" compromised the npm account of an Axios maintainer, publishing two malicious library versions embedding the "WAVESHAPER.V2" remote-access tool. With over 100 million weekly downloads, Axios is widely used in manufacturing sector industrial platforms and internal tooling, exposing operational systems to silent credential theft and second-stage payload deployment.

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■ March 31, 2026

Device Code Phishing Targets Microsoft 365 Accounts

A device code phishing campaign is compromising Microsoft 365 accounts by abusing legitimate authentication flows to steal valid access and refresh tokens. Threat actors use proxy infrastructure for token replay and suspicious mailbox access, posing a risk of business email compromise (BEC) and data theft to manufacturing sector organizations reliant on Microsoft 365 for operations.

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■ March 31, 2026

FortiClient EMS SQL Injection Actively Exploited

A critical pre-authentication SQLi vulnerability, CVE-2026-21643, in Fortinet FortiClient EMS 7.4.4 is being actively exploited. Manufacturing sector organizations relying on EMS for endpoint management face risks of credential theft, lateral movement, and downstream compromise, as a public proof-of-concept exploit lowers the barrier for less sophisticated threat actors.

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■ March 30, 2026

Notable Developments

Trivy Supply-Chain Compromise Targets CI/CD Pipelines

A trojanized Trivy version 0.69.4 was published through its official GitHub repository after a maintainer account was compromised. The malicious release harvested over 50 credential types, including Amazon Web Services (AWS) keys and Kubernetes secrets, from CI/CD pipelines. For the manufacturing sector, compromised cloud credentials risk unauthorized access to operational infrastructure and production environment secrets.

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■ March 20, 2026

Zendesk Impersonation Domains Target Support Portals

Researchers at ReliaQuest identified a surge in domains impersonating Zendesk via typosquatting, linked to phishing and credential theft. For the manufacturing sector, compromised support-platform credentials likely enable unauthorized access to ticketing systems and downstream workflows, increasing the risk of fraud, data exposure, and operational disruption.

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■ March 9, 2026